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Designing interactive systems: People, activities, contexts, technologies
Chapter 10: Envisionment

Even though the material in this chapter was written in a way that was quite easy to understand, I found that the simplicity of some of the key heuristics and approaches that were articulated is actually quite valuable. And although putting envisionment as “making ideas visible” sounds like a simple concept to understand, we can see that the actual practice of doing this successfully is not trivial. This is something I struggled to do a little in my own research, where I had to explain the concept of an audio tool I was creating to my advisor (and other audience). But it was difficult to get them to understand what exactly it was, and eventually I was the most successful when I created a structured visual diagram that explained how the audio changes by different parameters over time. Of course this is not like the design ideas described in the chapter, but I think that the chapter made me think more deeply about exactly how these different types of envisionment can affect the results of our communicating ideas with other people, and how to take both social and mental contexts into account when making decisions about what type to use.

My favorite part was how the chapter explained ways of interface navigation via landscape metaphors for different geographical terrain: wilderness, desert, night sky, and open sea. All of their differences are characterized by qualities such as how they make the user feel, their physical structure, and constituents. Although the chapter does not want to “suggest that the interface to a particular product looks like [any of these things]”, I think it is still useful and possible to characterize an interface by more than one landscape metaphor, to facilitate better understanding of the idea by comparing it to information people are already familiar with (landscape qualities).

Some other simple but important concepts that were new to me, were the concept of characterizing products of envisionment as hot and cold media. I never thought of media this way before, but I think it is really important to differentiate between media that is meant to make someone think compared to media that is meant to feed information. However, I am also interested in the complexities and any special implications that media lying in the middle of this spectrum may have.